



YOU ARE **26 WEEKS AND 3 DAYS**

95 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

Your baby sticks their tongue out often especially before or after a particularly large gulp of amniotic fluid. Fluid doesn't enter the lungs but is swallowed into the stomach. Your baby is completely unaware of the ultrasound scan, so is not reacting to the scanner.

“It's a natural instinct that parents are fiercely protective of their children, and not unusual for this to start well before the birth.”

You may be feeling very protective of your belly and baby. The belly almost acts as a beacon to other people, making them aware that you're pregnant. It's not unusual to feel quite vulnerable, for example, in a jostling crowd or when you're out shopping. When this happens, make it clear to people that you're pregnant and, hopefully, they'll give you more space and give up their seat, if necessary.

When you're driving, you may find you're doing so even more carefully than normal, or becoming a very nervous or critical passenger. You may become more irritated than usual by people who you feel are driving without concern for your safety.

This protective instinct is a natural part of becoming a mother. It's the desire to protect and nurture your child, even before yourself.

Rest assured, though, that your baby is in the safest possible environment inside your uterus. Your body is providing your baby with warmth, food, and oxygen. The baby is cushioned and protected by the amniotic fluid in which he floats, and this acts as a buffer to any shoving or bumping by crowds of people.

HYPNOBIRTHING

Giving birth in such a relaxed state that you barely feel pain sounds too good to be true. But the research extolling the benefits of hypnobirthing is impressive. Several studies have shown that self-hypnosis helps women feel less anxious about labor and birth. They also tend to require minimal pain relief and medical intervention and many succeed in giving birth at home. Look online for classes or ask your doctor.

- **You will learn a series of self-hypnosis**, relaxation, visualization, and breathing techniques that help you approach childbirth in a calm, positive frame of mind.
- **You should feel in control** of your body and able to manage the pain of labor.
- **The key is to practice frequently**, and a supportive birth partner is invaluable for helping you perfect the techniques and use them in labor.

ASK A DOCTOR
